Knowing Rohit's penchant to attack bowlers from the start, the Aussies threw the Glenn Maxwell—a part-time off-spinner—bait at him as early as the eighth over. By the time Maxwell came around for his second over, Rohit had risen to the bait hook, line and sinker.

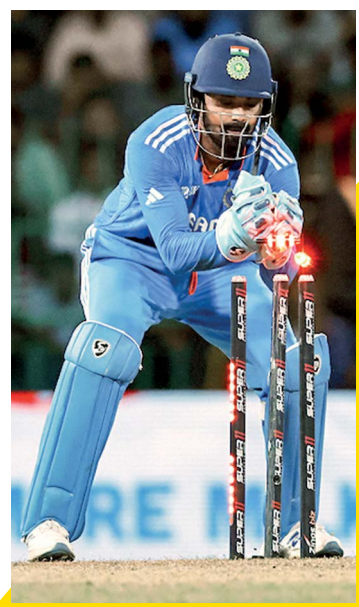
Shreyas Iyer, fresh from two back-to-back centuries, then fell for the oldest trick in the book—the short-ball bluff. He had been irked by short ball-related questions in press conferences, something that clearly didn't escape the Aussies. On cue, four Aussie fielders manned the boundary, two on the leg side and two on the off, all behind square—a copybook short-ball set-up—as soon as Iyer took guard against Pat Cummins. And when Cummins threw down a decoy in the form of a good length delivery, Iyer found himself stuck inside the crease, edging a delivery he should have been playing forward to.

With Virat and Rahul on the crease as early as the 11th over and having to bat according to the set template—respecting the conditions (dry pitch) and situation (cannot afford to expose SKY before the 35th over)—the Aussies had the Indians exactly where they wanted them to be. India's rigid plan now played into Aussie hands. Four boundaries in 40 overs are all India managed from here on, an unheard statistic in present-day white-ball cricket.

By the time the Indian innings folded, the newly devised Aussie counter-plan had trumped India's weeks' old, set formula. In effect, the template that had played to India's advantage thus far also, in a way, proved to be their downfall. And while there's no doubting Australia's indomitable spirit and big match temperament, their tactical planning may still remain the top reason behind them lifting their sixth world title.

An underrated aspect of India's World Cup campaign was how good they were in the field. They rarely dropped catches and fielded like their lives depended on it. The introduction of the 'best fielder' medal, handed out in the dressing room after every game, had the desired effect. Such was the determination to excel that K.L. Rahul, a stand-in wicket-keeper at best, pulled off some absolute blinders behind the stumps, was solid with his glove work and was rated by experts as being amongst the best in the tournament

A FIELDING UNIT PAR EXCELLENCE



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Despite another heartbreak, the reversal in the final is unlikely to alter Indian cricket in a major way. But one facet of Indian cricket that does need a rethink is the tendency of preparing overly dry pitches at home in an effort to spook opponents. It is a ploy that has backfired on occasions. The final was a perfect example. India had to bat on a dry surface where the double-paced nature of the pitch meant the team batting first was worse-off. As a result, the hosts ended up neutralising their superiority in terms of personnel and form over Australia and allowed the elements to play their part in deciding the winner on the night.

And though norms dictate that the responsibility of preparing the pitch during an ICC tournament rests solely with the International Cricket Council, it's no secret that local curators pay heed to the demands of the home team.

"If you had a good batting pitch in the finals, a 300-plus kind of pitch, India would have had a much better chance of winning," 2011 World Cup winner Harbhajan Singh tells INDIA TODAY. "Remember, this is the team that beat Australia in a Test series in their own backyard. Then why must we play on pitches that allow conditions to play a major role in the result?"

Even as India's memorable World Cup campaign comes to an end, the question remains: what must India do to end its long wait for an ICC trophy? The finals of the 2023 World Cup should serve up as the perfect lesson. ■